

knock your socks off. A glorious top-end awaits you at the upper echelons of the audible sonic spectrum. The Cowon iAudio 7 loses out by a hair's breadth, but bass on the iAudio 7 is astounding—a deep hit-in-the-gut feeling that was especially noticeable with the circum-aural Audio Technica reference cans. Once again, we must caution you—such detailing is only possible on *good* headphones. The default earbuds that ship with even some of the best players are atrociously short of any kind of aural experience, and if you're serious about sound, you'll chuck them out.

The YES YMP 45, Philips GoGear and Mitashi MWI-4GA just aren't in the same league as the above mentioned PMPs, and the Sony NWZ-S615F and Creative Zen 4 GB fall slap-bang in the middle of the best and the rest.

If you're looking for primarily a video player, then you should look at another category. The YES YMP 45, Creative Zen, and the Mitashi MWI-4GA have the largest screens—and size matters when you're talking anything visual. The Creative Zen will win the race for the best video PMP, because it's got a better screen, and has excellent music quality to begin with.



iriverX20
Feature rich 'n flashy

Conclusion

Our graphs reveal two products standing a little taller than the rest—amazingly, the Apple iPod Nano 3G and the iRiver X20 score exactly the same, even after having slightly different features and a bit of a performance gap. While its sheer audio quality, compact build, looks and extensive feature list are enough to make the Nano stand out in any company, the more suave iRiver matches it very closely. The Nano is especially recommended for those looking for something compact yet powerful—it offers the smallest footprint and the best performance (albeit by the smallest of margins). But if you take a look at the third dimension—the price—things begin to change. The Samsung YP-S5 offers the biggest bang for the buck—it's a marvellously well built device, the touch controls are as precise as clockwork, and it comes very close to both the Nano and the X20 in terms of performance. We find no serious reason to nitpick—it's even got speakers! Our *Best Buy* award belongs to the second-cheapest

device in the entire category—the Samsung YP-S5, it'll just about be the best Rs 6,600 you've ever spent.

Cowon's iAudio 7 and SanDisk's Sansa E280 also have a nice mix of quality, storage space and features—highly recommended as well.

If you're looking for a video PMP with good audio quality, look at the Creative Zen—it offers the best of both worlds: good music quality and a superb screen. The YES YMP 45 and Mitashi MWI-4GA could also interest you, but audio quality takes something of a nosedive.

FLASH-BASED PMPS

Above Rs 10,000

By now, all memories of tonal colouring, recessed mid-ranges and boomy bass have gone (but not forgotten), the pockets are a little deeper, the audience more discerning and expectations skyrocket. If you're part of the small but growing group of consumers who are willing to shell out in excess of four figures on a PMP, you'll probably grin at the above statement. Such PMPs have an uphill task ahead of them—they should excel a couple of things, while still retaining excellence for all other areas of functionality.

 Apple iPod Nano 3G 8 GB: Tiny Dancer

If you thought the older model was compact due to its slimness, wait till you lay eyes on the new one. It's shrunk to nearly half the length of the previous Nano while getting a couple of millimetres wider, and also getting a better, bigger screen in the bargain. The conscious attempt at space-saving is unabashedly evident, and the 3G is more "nano" than ever.

It's a very well built device, although the smudge- and scratch-prone rear will have you using a case whenever you take it around. The 3G Nano supports video playback, and with this move, Apple has just raised the bar for the compact PMPs—no other model in this class has comparable features. Why no FM? Simple...why listen to radio stations when you can listen to your favourite numbers with four (and eight) gigabytes of storage space?

Audio quality is class-leading and the Nano is within a hair's breadth of the quality of the iPod Touch, which for us

was the best sounding PMP, period. Second place is not a bad place to be, especially when both are flying the same colours. The Nano approaches the same kind of deep, pounding yet lively bass that the Touch has, there's no hint of flab or colouring of any sort, and in tracks like *Hotel California*, the drum score in the beginning will cause you to close your eyes and sigh with satisfaction. It gets better with the mid-range, as guitar harmonics have that very live feel, there's no over-emphasis on tones like some players—if there's a sound in the recording, you'll hear it the way it was produced—accurate to a fault. With a fully revealed top-end, the Nano will satisfy lovers of high frequency instruments like saxophones and violins. We got the chance to audition a couple of



Yanni DVDs—we daresay the maestro himself would be pleased.

The other little utilities like a calendar, alarm, contacts and stopwatch are all present as are three engaging little games, with more stuff downloadable from the iTunes store (which isn't available in India, unfortunately).

The Nano positions itself in a league just below the iPod Touch in price, but serves a very different audience. We don't see anyone (for example) working out with the Touch in their pocket. In fact, a user who could afford to buy both PMPs—so different are they from each other. What they share in common is brilliance of design, usability and performance. If you're looking for something that's compact and powerful while retaining stellar performance—and that too under Rs 10,000—you'd be daft to even consider anything else.

Cowon A3: One PMP To Own Them All

A shiny off-white pearl finish, a contoured body with sleek steel buttons down the front side of the fascia in a neat row, and with dark grey trimming on the outer bezel, sporting powerful hardware under the hood, a brilliant view to the action, and a look that's in a class of its own. You'd be forgiven for thinking we're writing an advertisement for the latest Aston Martin or something. It is the proverbial Bentley amongst PMPs though, and the moment we laid eyes on it, we knew we beheld something special.



To power itself, the A3 uses a DaVinci dual-core processor. If your wondering where that came from or why Cowon decided on overkill, let us tell you that this device is the first of its kind to actually support 720p HD content natively without any transcoding. Imagine dragging huge .VOB files to a PMP and enjoying skip-free video. Or imagine playing a 50 MB audio file in all its FLAC splendour without a hiccup. The A3 does it all. About the only trick Cowon missed is the gimmicky and “in” touchscreen, but we’re told they have another A3-like PMP called the Q5W lined up, which addresses “touchaholics”.

The A3 is a very good music player, and does everything right if it's all you listen to. The iPod Touch and the Nano highlight the sonic limitations of the A3, unfortunately. Another little niggle is the volume level of the A3, which isn't satisfactorily loud. But once you fire up a video on this baby, prepare to be blown away—the A3 is all rampaging performance, a video player on steroids that delivers quite a wallop for the money you pay. It's got an AV-out cable as well, which means you can take the action-onscreen. We tried a 720p movie on the A3 on our 32-inch LCD screen and the experience was as good as any HD DVD player. All the regular features—Cowon's full-fledged equaliser, FM radio, photo viewing, and voice recording—are also present. should you need them.

Quite simply put, if you need the best video PMP around, this is your safest bet. It's also your cheapest bet, as both 30 GB and 60 GB versions are cheaper than Creative's sole challenger, the Vision W. Do remember that its bulky and also heavy, so its not something you'll slip into your denims, its intended as a micro *home* theatre, so please keep it there.

Features

Right off the block, Apple's iPod Touch duo (8 and 16 GB models) impresses with just a glance. The rear, chrome plated and buffed to a mirror-like sheen will only make the black front—devoid of any buttons save one large and dimpled menu button—stand out. A large and crisp touchscreen (identical to the iPhone's) greets you. Menu navigation is a snap, and the much-vaunted *Touch-flo* isn't just hype—it really works! You're never lost too deep in the Touch's menu subsystem, a press of the aforementioned button and you back on the main menu. Icons are bright, well laid-out and everything seems designed with usability in mind. Browsing is fun with finger swipes, particularly when resizing and zooming in on photos with your fingers onscreen. The inbuilt gyroscope means the Touch reorients its screen for your viewing convenience when it's tilted.

The Apple iPod Nano 3G makes another appearance in an

8 GB guise, as does the iRiver X20 (4 and 8 GB). Creative's Zen was another familiar face, and the 8 GB version finds itself amongst the upper echelons of the Flash-based players. The only real newcomer is the Cowon D2, a device which won our *Best Buy* award last year. The Cowon has a nice crisp touchscreen; though the screen icons don't look too clear, this is a 16 million-colour LCD and it makes its presence felt later. It also supports text and PDF, besides the usual features like voice recording and FM radio.

Performance

Up front, the Apples were clearly distinct from the oranges and everything else, and with the exception of the stalwart Cowon D2, Mr Jobs' offerings would hog the limelight. Cowon's D2 is really a superb performer and sonically very nearly nirvana. A full extension throughout the audible spectrum—an excellent low-ends and fully revealed mid-



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